

PSY405 - Lesson 25

Core Concepts of George Kelly's Cognitive Theory of Personality

Recap of Lecture 24

Before diving into today's material, remember Kelly's theory is:

1. **Phenomenological** – focuses on **how the individual experiences and interprets the world** (your internal frame of reference). Example: Two people can watch the same movie, one finds it funny, the other boring.
2. **Cognitive** – studies **mental processes** like thinking, predicting, and interpreting.
3. **Existential** – emphasizes **future orientation and freedom to choose**. People are not just reacting to the past—they actively shape the future.
4. **Humanistic** – highlights **human creativity, optimism, and problem-solving ability**.

Kelly believed that **people behave and think based on “personal constructs”**—mental templates used to predict what will happen. Examples: *good vs. bad*, *friendly vs. hostile*.

Core Concepts - Lecture 25

7. A Postulate and Some Corollaries

Kelly's theory has **one main postulate** and **11 corollaries**.

Postulate:

"A person's processes are psychologically channelized by the ways in which he anticipates events."

- In simple words: How you think and behave is guided by how you predict the future.

Corollaries: These are rules that explain how constructs work:

1. **Construction corollary** – We **form constructs based on patterns in experience**.
 - Example: If you meet 10 friendly dogs, you construct “dogs = friendly.”
 2. **Individual corollary** – Everyone has a **unique set of constructs**, even if experiences are similar.
 3. **Organization corollary** – Constructs are **hierarchically organized** in the mind. Some are core, others are peripheral.
 4. **Dichotomy corollary** – Constructs are **bipolar**, meaning they work in opposites (friendly vs. hostile, good vs. bad).
 5. **Choice corollary** – People **choose constructs that best predict and extend their system**.
 - Example: You might use “hardworking vs. lazy” to judge a coworker, because it helps you anticipate their behavior.
 6. **Range corollary** – Each construct is **applicable only to certain situations**.
 - Example: “Friendly vs. hostile” applies to people, not rocks.
 7. **Experience corollary** – We **modify constructs based on repeated experiences**.
 8. **Modulation corollary** – Some constructs are **more flexible (permeable)**, while others are rigid.
 9. **Fragmentation corollary** – People can be **inconsistent** when testing new constructs.
 10. **Commonality corollary** – People are similar if they **construct events in similar ways**.
 11. **Sociality corollary** – To interact with others, we **anticipate how they will act** and adjust our behavior.
-

8. Channelizing Processes

Kelly used this fancy term to explain that **our thinking and behavior are “channeled” by how we anticipate events.**

- Example: If you expect it will rain, you carry an umbrella. Your action is guided by anticipation.
-

9. Individuality and Organization

- Everyone interprets events **uniquely**, even identical twins.
 - Example: Political opinions—people can experience the same facts but have completely different interpretations.
 - Think of this as looking through **personal construct “goggles.”**
-

10. To Construe or Not to Construe

- **Construe** = to interpret or make sense of experiences.
 - Kelly’s choice corollary says we **choose the interpretation that gives the most understanding and prediction power.**
-

11. C-P-C Cycle (Circumspection–Preemption–Control)

This is **how we deal with new situations:**

1. **Circumspection** – Consider many possible interpretations (constructs).
 2. **Preemption** – Narrow down to the most relevant constructs.
 3. **Control** – Act based on the chosen construct.
- Example: You see a stranger approaching.
 - Circumspection: “Are they friend or foe?”
 - Preemption: “They’re waving, probably friendly.”
 - Control: Smile and wave back.
-

12. Change in a Construct System

- We **update constructs** when new experiences don’t fit old predictions.

- This is called **construct revision**.
 - Example: You thought dogs are always friendly, then a dog bites you—you revise your “dogs are friendly” construct.
-

13. Social Relationships and Personal Constructs

- People are **similar if they construe experiences similarly**, not just because they share experiences.
 - Example: Two people who see helping others as important will behave similarly, even if their life experiences are different.
-

14. Role Construct Repertory (Rep) Test

- A tool to **map a person’s important constructs**.
 - The test asks you to compare **people in your life** (self, parents, teachers, friends) to uncover how you construe relationships.
 - Example of role titles:
 1. Self – yourself
 2. Mother – your mother or mother figure
 3. Father – your father or father figure
 4. Boss, Teacher, Doctor, Happy person, etc.
-

15. Application: Emotional States

Kelly redefined emotions based on **construct systems**:

1. **Anxiety** – Realized your constructs can’t predict an event.
 - Example: First time giving a speech—you don’t know what to expect.
2. **Guilt** – When you violate a personal role or expectation.
 - Example: A student who sees themselves as a scholar feels guilty for skipping study to play games.
3. **Hostility** – Trying to **force validation for a failed construct**.

- Example: Insisting a friend is “trustworthy” despite repeated betrayals.
-

16. Psychological Health

Healthy people:

1. **Test and evaluate their constructs**—don’t blindly stick to them.
 2. **Discard or revise invalid constructs**—they are **permeable**.
- Example: A healthy person changes opinion about a friend after discovering repeated lies, instead of ignoring evidence.
-

17. Fixed-Role Therapy

- Therapy focuses on **reconstructing the client’s construct system**.
 - Clients **experiment with new roles** to see what fits better.
 - Key steps:
 1. Write a **third-person sketch of yourself**.
 2. Experiment with acting according to this new perspective.
 3. Get **feedback** to validate or adjust constructs.
 - Example: A shy person practices a confident persona in therapy to build new social constructs.
-

18. Summary

- **Constructive Alternativism** – Reality is **subjective**; everyone interprets differently.
 - People are like **scientists**, constantly testing hypotheses about life.
 - Personality = **unique system of constructs**.
 - Constructs have **properties**: range of convenience, focus, permeability.
 - Therapy = **testing and revising constructs** to improve psychological health.
-

19. Evaluation

- Kelly's theory is:
 - **Phenomenological** – focuses on subjective experience
 - **Cognitive** – emphasizes thinking and anticipation
 - **Existential & Humanistic** – free choice, future-oriented, meaningful life
 - Each person **creates unique constructs** to reduce uncertainty and navigate reality.
-

✓ Key Takeaways:

1. You see the world through your **personal constructs**.
2. Everyone has a **unique perspective**—no two people interpret the same event exactly alike.
3. We **predict and act** based on these constructs.
4. Constructs **change with experience**; healthy people revise them.
5. Therapy helps you **experiment with new ways of thinking and acting**.

SHORT QUESTIONS

1. What is the fundamental postulate of George Kelly's Cognitive Theory of Personality?

Answer:

The fundamental postulate of Kelly's theory states that **a person's psychological processes are guided by the ways in which they anticipate future events**. In other words, the way people think, feel, and behave is determined by their predictions about what will happen in the future.

Explanation:

Kelly believed humans are not passive; we are like scientists constantly **trying to predict the future**. Our thoughts and behaviors are shaped not by the past alone but by what we think will happen next. This is why he emphasized anticipation.

Example:

If you believe it will rain tomorrow, you take an umbrella. Your behavior (taking an umbrella) is based on your anticipation of future events.

Tips:

- Remember the keyword **"anticipation"** – Kelly is all about predicting future events.
 - Think: "We act based on what we expect, not just what has already happened."
-

2. What are personal constructs? Give examples.

Answer:

Personal constructs are **mental templates or categories that individuals use to interpret and predict events**. They are bipolar, meaning they usually have two opposite poles, such as *friendly vs. hostile* or *successful vs. unsuccessful*.

Explanation:

A construct is like a lens through which you see the world. Everyone has their own set of constructs, which helps them make sense of life and anticipate what might happen. These constructs are unique to each person.

Example:

- A student may see classmates as *hardworking vs. lazy*.
- A teacher may see students as *motivated vs. unmotivated*.

Tips:

- Think **"mental filters"** – constructs filter reality for us.
 - Remember: constructs are **bipolar**, always with opposites.
-

3. What is constructive alternativism?

Answer:

Constructive alternativism is Kelly's philosophical principle stating that **there is no single objective reality; reality is open to interpretation, and individuals can revise their understanding based on experience**.

Explanation:

Kelly argued that the world does not dictate one truth. People actively create their own version of reality, and they can change it when new information or experiences arise. It emphasizes flexibility.

Example:

You thought a coworker was unfriendly because they were quiet, but after talking, you realize they are just shy. You revise your understanding – this is constructive alternativism.

Tips:

- Remember **"alternative interpretations"**.
 - Think: Reality = flexible, subjective, and testable, just like a scientist revising a hypothesis.
-

4. What are the 11 corollaries of Kelly's theory? Briefly explain their meaning.

Answer:

The corollaries are rules that explain how personal constructs operate:

1. **Construction corollary** – We build constructs from repeated experiences.
2. **Individual corollary** – Everyone has unique constructs.
3. **Organization corollary** – Constructs are arranged hierarchically.
4. **Dichotomy corollary** – Constructs are bipolar (opposites).
5. **Choice corollary** – We select constructs that help us extend our system.
6. **Range corollary** – Each construct applies to certain situations.
7. **Experience corollary** – Constructs are revised through experience.
8. **Modulation corollary** – Some constructs are flexible, some rigid.
9. **Fragmentation corollary** – People can be inconsistent in applying constructs.
10. **Commonality corollary** – People are similar if they interpret events similarly.
11. **Sociality corollary** – Understanding others' constructs helps us interact.

Explanation:

Corollaries are like rules of the game for our mental constructs. They explain how we create, use, and change constructs and how this affects relationships and behavior.

Example:

- **Choice corollary:** You may judge a new colleague as “organized” because this helps you predict their behavior.
- **Sociality corollary:** To get along with your boss, you understand what they expect and adjust your behavior.

Tips:

- Think: “**Construction, Individual, Organization, Dichotomy, Choice...**” – first letters = **CIODC** (helps memorize).
 - Remember: corollaries explain **how we interpret and interact with the world.**
-

5. What is the C-P-C cycle?

Answer:

The C-P-C cycle stands for **Circumspection–Preemption–Control**, describing how individuals approach new situations:

1. **Circumspection** – Consider possible constructs relevant to the situation.
2. **Preemption** – Choose the constructs that seem most relevant.
3. **Control** – Act based on the chosen constructs.

Explanation:

This is how people process new events and decide how to respond. It shows the active, cognitive nature of human behavior.

Example:

You meet a stranger at a party:

- Circumspection: “Are they friendly or unfriendly?”
- Preemption: “They’re smiling, probably friendly.”

- Control: You smile and start a conversation.

Tips:

- Remember **"C-P-C = Think-Select-Act"**.
 - Think of it as **a mini decision-making process** in your mind.
-

6. How does change occur in a construct system?

Answer:

Change occurs when **new experiences do not fit existing constructs**, forcing individuals to revise or replace them. This is called **construct revision**.

Explanation:

Our constructs are like mental models. If reality does not match our predictions, we must update our model. This process allows growth and adaptability.

Example:

Believing "dogs are always friendly" until bitten by a dog → revise the construct to "dogs can be friendly or aggressive."

Tips:

- Keywords: **novel experience, revision, flexibility**.
 - Think: Healthy people **adapt constructs to reality**; rigid people do not.
-

7. How are social relationships explained in Kelly's theory?

Answer:

Kelly explained social relationships as **interactions guided by how similarly people construe events**. People are similar in behavior if they interpret experiences similarly, not just because of shared experiences.

Explanation:

It's not what you experience but **how you interpret it** that predicts similarity in behavior. Understanding others' constructs helps in communication and social

interaction.

Example:

Two friends both value honesty. Even if their life experiences differ, they behave similarly when handling moral dilemmas.

Tips:

- Keyword: **“psychological similarity”**, not just experience similarity.
 - Think: Relationships = **matching perspectives**.
-

8. What is the Role Construct Repertory (Rep) Test?

Answer:

The Rep Test is a **psychological tool to identify the personal constructs an individual uses to interpret significant people** in their life.

Explanation:

By comparing key people (self, family, friends, teachers), therapists can see **patterns in how clients construe relationships**. This helps in understanding personality and designing therapy.

Example:

You may describe your mother, father, and best friend on dimensions like *caring* vs. *neglectful*, revealing your personal constructs about relationships.

Tips:

- Think **“map of your social constructs.”**
 - Useful for **therapy and personality assessment**.
-

9. How does Kelly explain emotional states like anxiety, guilt, and hostility?

Answer:

- **Anxiety:** Feeling helpless when constructs fail to predict events.
- **Guilt:** Awareness of violating personal roles or important self-standards.

- **Hostility:** Persisting with invalid constructs despite evidence they fail.

Explanation:

Kelly redefined emotions in terms of **construct effectiveness**. Emotional problems arise when our mental models do not work well with reality.

Example:

- Anxiety: First day at a new job, unsure of expectations.
- Guilt: Skipping study time, violating "good student" role.
- Hostility: Insisting a dishonest friend is trustworthy despite repeated evidence.

Tips:

- Keywords: **construct failure** → **emotional state**.
 - Think: Emotions = **feedback from construct system**.
-

10. What is psychological health according to Kelly?

Answer:

A psychologically healthy person:

1. Evaluates and tests their constructs.
2. Discards invalid constructs and updates their core role system.
3. Shows flexibility and adaptability in interpreting events.

Explanation:

Health = being able to revise your mental templates based on experience, not stubbornly sticking to wrong beliefs. Permeable constructs = adaptive mind.

Example:

Changing opinion about a colleague after realizing they are trustworthy, instead of holding on to suspicion.

Tips:

- Keyword: **permeable constructs**.
 - Think: Health = **flexibility + testing reality**.
-

11. What is fixed-role therapy?

Answer:

Fixed-role therapy is a therapeutic technique where clients **experiment with new constructs and roles to reconstruct their personality**. The therapist helps by providing feedback to validate these new constructs.

Explanation:

The client writes a **third-person sketch of themselves**, adopts new behaviors, tests them in life, and updates their construct system. Therapy = laboratory for experimenting with new ways of seeing and acting.

Example:

A shy person writes a third-person description as "confident and sociable" and practices acting confidently at social events.

Tips:

- Keywords: **experiment, feedback, new role.**
- Think: Therapy = **scientific testing of new constructs.**

1. True/False Questions

1. **Kelly's fundamental postulate states that a person's behavior is entirely determined by past experiences.**

- **Answer:** False
- **Explanation:** Kelly emphasized anticipation of future events, not just past experiences.

1. **Personal constructs are bipolar in nature.**

- **Answer:** True
- **Explanation:** Each construct has two opposite poles, like *friendly vs. hostile*.

1. **Constructive alternativism implies that reality is fixed and cannot be interpreted differently.**

- **Answer:** False

- **Explanation:** Constructive alternativism states that reality is subjective and open to interpretation.
1. **A healthy person is characterized by rigid constructs that never change.**
 - **Answer:** False
 - **Explanation:** Health in Kelly's theory is the ability to revise constructs when needed (permeable constructs).
 1. **The sociality corollary emphasizes understanding others' constructs to interact successfully.**
 - **Answer:** True
 - **Explanation:** Social interaction depends on predicting how others construe events.
-

2. Conceptual MCQs

1. **Which of the following best defines a "personal construct"?**
 - A. A fixed personality trait that cannot change
 - B. A mental template used to interpret and predict events
 - C. A genetic factor determining behavior
 - D. A habit formed by past rewards
 - **Answer:** B
 - **Explanation:** Personal constructs are cognitive categories (like mental templates) used to interpret experiences.
-
1. **Which corollary states that constructs apply only to certain situations?**
 - A. Choice corollary
 - B. Range corollary
 - C. Modulation corollary
 - D. Experience corollary
 - **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Range corollary defines the “range of convenience” for a construct—where it is applicable.
-

1. **Which statement best reflects the constructive alternativism principle?**

- A. Reality is objectively fixed for everyone.
- B. Reality is subjective and can be revised based on new experiences.
- C. Past experiences alone determine our constructs.
- D. People cannot change their interpretations of reality.

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Kelly believed that people actively interpret reality and can revise their constructs.
-

1. **The C-P-C cycle includes:**

- A. Circumspection, Preemption, Control
- B. Construction, Prediction, Correction
- C. Choice, Prediction, Confirmation
- D. Circumstance, Prejudice, Control

- **Answer:** A

- **Explanation:** C-P-C = Circumspection (consider constructs), Preemption (choose relevant), Control (act based on constructs).
-

1. **Hostility in Kelly’s theory is:**

- A. A disposition to physically harm others
- B. The continued attempt to validate a failed construct
- C. A fear of social rejection
- D. An uncontrollable emotional reaction

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Hostility occurs when a person insists on validating a construct that has already failed.
-

3. Situational MCQs

1. **Ahmed believes all teachers are strict. On the first day, his new teacher is kind and supportive. According to Kelly, what is likely to happen?**

A. Ahmed ignores the experience and continues his old belief
B. Ahmed revises his construct to include the possibility of kind teachers
C. Ahmed becomes hostile toward the teacher
D. Ahmed develops anxiety only

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Exposure to a novel experience challenges the construct; healthy construct revision occurs.

1. **Sara writes a third-person sketch describing herself as confident and sociable and practices these behaviors in social situations. Which Kellyian therapy is she using?**

A. Psychoanalysis
B. Fixed-role therapy
C. Cognitive behavioral therapy
D. Humanistic therapy

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Fixed-role therapy involves acting out new constructs to reconstruct personality.

1. **Two friends interpret the same political event differently: one sees it as positive, the other as negative. Kelly would say this difference is due to:**

A. Genetic traits
B. Past experiences alone
C. Different personal constructs
D. Social pressure

- **Answer:** C

- **Explanation:** Individuality corollary: each person construes events uniquely.
-

1. **A student feels anxious because they have no idea how the professor will grade the assignment. According to Kelly, this anxiety arises because:**

- A. They are lazy
- B. Their constructs cannot predict the event
- C. They have a poor personality
- D. They fear social rejection

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Anxiety occurs when available constructs fail to anticipate an event.
-

1. **If two coworkers behave similarly despite different backgrounds, Kelly would explain this as:**

- A. Coincidence
- B. Similar interpretation of events
- C. Influence of organizational culture only
- D. Same IQ level

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Commonality corollary – people are similar if their constructs function similarly.
-

4. Bonus Tricky MCQs

1. **Which of the following is NOT an aspect of a healthy construct system according to Kelly?**

- A. Permeability of constructs
- B. Willingness to test constructs
- C. Rigid adherence to all previous constructs
- D. Ability to discard invalid constructs

- **Answer:** C

- **Explanation:** Rigidity is unhealthy; flexibility is key to psychological health.

1. **Which corollary best explains why even identical twins may perceive the same event differently?**

- A. Commonality corollary
- B. Individual corollary
- C. Modulation corollary
- D. Organization corollary

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Individual corollary – everyone construes events uniquely, regardless of similarity in genetics or experience.

1. **A client insists that a previously failed behavior pattern is correct despite repeated failures. This demonstrates:**

- A. Guilt
- B. Hostility
- C. Anxiety
- D. Circumspection

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Hostility = persisting with invalid constructs to gain validation.

1. **Circumspection in the C-P-C cycle is most similar to:**

- A. Acting impulsively
- B. Considering multiple options before deciding
- C. Testing the final action
- D. Ignoring alternatives

- **Answer:** B

- **Explanation:** Circumspection = thinking over possible constructs before choosing the best one.

Cheat Sheet

1. Core Idea

- **Humans = Scientists:** Constantly generating and testing hypotheses to predict future events.
- **Personality = Personal Construct System**
- **Reality = Subjective:** Constructive alternativism → Reality is what you construe it to be.

Memory hook: *"Kelly = Cognitive Scientist of the Mind"*

2. Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example
Personal Construct	Mental template to interpret and predict events	<i>Friendly vs Hostile</i>
Constructive Alternativism	Reality is flexible, open to interpretation	Revising belief about a shy coworker after conversation
Circumspection	Considering all possible constructs	Thinking "Is the stranger friendly or hostile?"
Preemption	Selecting relevant constructs	Choosing "friendly" based on smile
Control	Acting based on chosen construct	Smiling and greeting the stranger
Permeable Construct	Flexible, open to change	Changing "dogs are always friendly" after being bitten
Range of Convenience	Situations where a construct is relevant	"Friendly vs Hostile" applies to people, not rocks

3. Fundamental Postulate

"A person's processes are psychologically channelized by the ways in which they anticipate events."

- **Plain English:** Behavior and thinking are guided by predictions about the future.
- **Tip:** Remember “channelized = guided”.

4. 11 Corollaries – Quick Table

Corollary	Key Idea	Keyword	Example
Construction	Constructs from patterns of experience	Pattern	Dogs = friendly after meeting many dogs
Individual	Everyone has unique constructs	Unique	Twins interpret same movie differently
Organization	Constructs are hierarchically arranged	Hierarchy	Core vs peripheral beliefs
Dichotomy	Constructs are bipolar	Opposites	Friendly vs Hostile
Choice	Select constructs that extend system	Selection	Judge coworker as organized for prediction
Range	Each construct applies to certain events	Scope	“Friendly vs hostile” → only people
Experience	Modify constructs based on experience	Revision	Dog bites → revise belief
Modulation	Some constructs more flexible	Flexibility	Adaptable vs rigid belief
Fragmentation	People can be inconsistent	Inconsistency	Acting differently in new social group
Commonality	People are similar if constructs are similar	Similarity	Two friends both value honesty
Sociality	Understand others' constructs to interact	Social	Predict boss's reaction, adjust behavior

Mnemonic: CIO-DC-REC-FCS → “Construct Individual Organization, Dichotomy Choice Range Experience Corollaries Flexible Commonality Sociality”

5. Emotional States (Kelly)

Emotion	Cause	Example
Anxiety	Constructs fail to predict event	New job, unsure expectations
Guilt	Violating personal role/standard	Student skips studying
Hostility	Persisting with failed construct	Insisting dishonest friend is trustworthy

Tip: *Emotions = feedback from construct system.*

6. C-P-C Cycle (Circumspection–Preemption–Control)

Phase	Action	Example
Circumspection	Consider many constructs	"Is the stranger friendly or unfriendly?"
Preemption	Select relevant construct	"They are smiling → friendly"
Control	Act based on construct	Smile and greet stranger

Memory hook: *"Think → Select → Act"*

7. Psychological Health

- Test constructs constantly
- Revise invalid constructs (**permeable constructs**)
- Adapt to reality
- **Tip:** *Rigid = unhealthy, flexible = healthy*

8. Role Construct Repertory (Rep) Test

- Identifies key personal constructs via comparison of **significant people** in life.
- **Role Titles Example:** Self, Mother, Father, Spouse, Teacher, Boss, Happy Person, Intelligent Person
- **Tip:** Think *"mapping your social mental filters"*

9. Fixed-Role Therapy

Goal: Reconstruct personality by experimenting with new constructs/roles.

Steps:

1. Write third-person sketch of self
2. Act according to new role
3. Test and validate with feedback
4. Adjust constructs accordingly

Example: Shy person writes: *"Confident and sociable"* → practices → updates self-concept.

Tip: Think of therapy as **scientific experimentation of personality**.

10. Quick Tips & Tricks

- **Remember all constructs are bipolar:** always two ends.
- **Construct revision = key to health** → flexible thinking
- **C-P-C = decision-making process** → Circumspect → Preempt → Control
- **Emotions reflect construct success/failure** → Anxiety, Guilt, Hostility
- **Sociality corollary** = understand others to interact effectively
- **Mnemonic for corollaries:** *"CIO-DC-REC-FCS"*